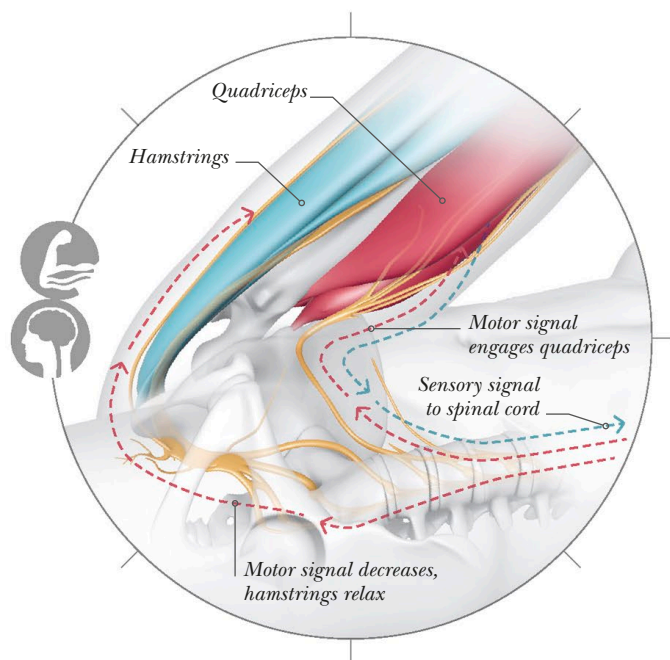


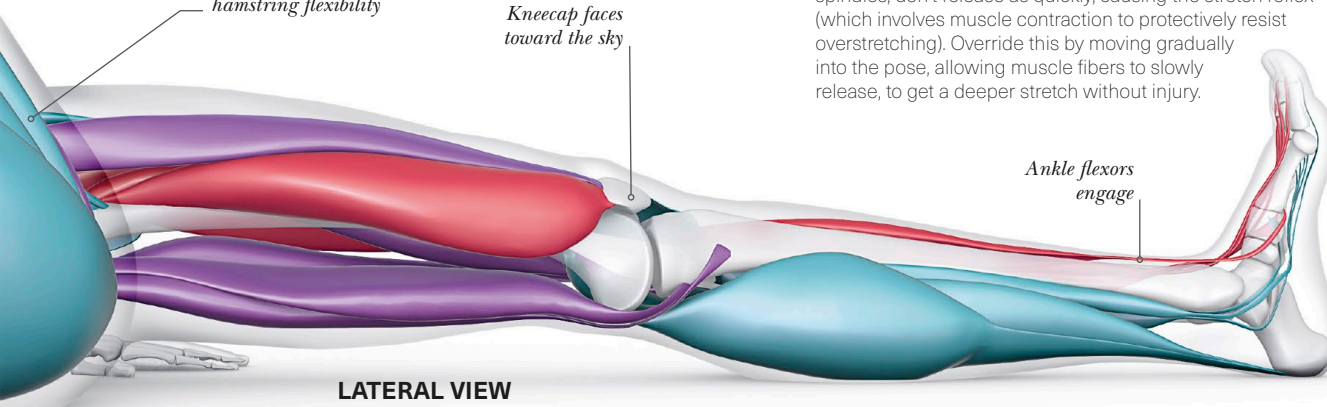


Reciprocal inhibition

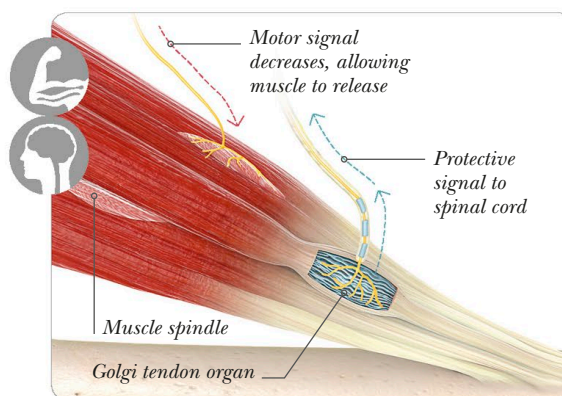
Muscles often work in pairs. You can use reciprocal inhibition (RI), a protective physiological phenomenon, to get a deeper stretch safely. To initiate RI, consciously engage your quadriceps for a few breaths. Nerves in your quadriceps send a message to the paired hamstrings, telling them to relax deeper into the stretch.

Research suggests a 20–30 second hold can increase hamstring flexibility

Kneecap faces toward the sky

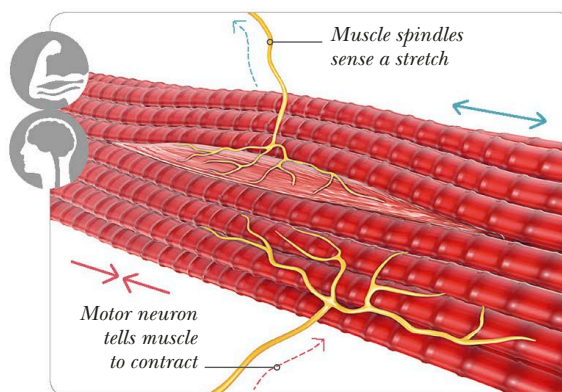


LATERAL VIEW



Release

When you first go into a stretching pose, you probably feel a taut pulling in your muscles. After a few breaths, tension peaks, and sensors in tendons called the Golgi tendon organ send a protective signal, inhibiting contraction and resistance in larger muscle fibers. This causes that pleasurable "ahhh" feeling of release.



Stretch reflex

Smaller muscle fibers with sensors, called muscle spindles, don't release as quickly, causing the stretch reflex (which involves muscle contraction to protectively resist overstretching). Override this by moving gradually into the pose, allowing muscle fibers to slowly release, to get a deeper stretch without injury.